

were ill or not. Now we're in danger of being unable to do anything without it being measured first.

Numbers and measurements are as vulnerable as the Emperor's New Clothes to the incisive, intuitive human question. The closer any of us get to measuring what's really important, the more it escapes us, yet we can recognize it, sometimes in an instant. Relying on that instant a bit more, and our ability to grasp it, is probably the best hope for us all.

But it is not just social critics who recognize that the role of counting must play second fiddle to the role of trusting. Hear exemplary business leader Bill George, former chief of medical technology pioneer Medtronic: "Trust is everything, because success depends upon customers' trust in the products they buy, employees' trust in their leaders, investors' trust in those who invest for them and the public's trust in capitalism. . . . If you do not have integrity, no one will trust you, nor should they."

An Empty Exercise

Please don't misunderstand me. I honor and respect counting. No one realizes better than I that business is demanding and competitive, and that many—indeed, most—business firms have lives that, in Thomas Hobbes's famous formulation, are "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short." We must either compete or die. In such circumstances, we have no alternative but to construct objective and measurable goals and hold those responsible accountable for their achievement. But I recognize as well the deep wisdom that is required to understand that, without trust, counting is at best an empty exercise and at worst a dangerous one.

Agree with me or not, but at least I'm consistent. In 1972, nearly 40 years ago, I closed my annual message to the employees of Wellington Management Company (which I then headed) with this